

## /research

Research system: /research create [--mode tiered|supervisor|competitive] ... | list | open | search | show | delete | archive | cluster

### Overview

/research drives the structured research pipeline: web search plus local file cross-referencing, synthesis, and a self-contained RESEARCH.md output. Projects are named, persisted, and can be listed, resumed, clustered, exported, and imported. Create accepts a rich flag set covering depth, tier, mode, per-stage models, concurrency, timeouts, and source limits. The TUI runs the pipeline on a background task while the status bar shows [wait] research: <name>....

### Syntax

```
/research help
/research create <name> <topic> [flags]
/research list [--all] [--json]
/research show <name> [--json]
/research open <name>
/research search <query> [--json]
/research delete <name> [--yes]
/research archive <name>
/research resume <name>
/research continue <name> [--message <text>]
/research update <name>
/research cluster <name> [--force]
/research export <name> [--output <path>]
/research import <path> [--name <name>]
/research config
```

The first positional after create is the project name; everything after it is the topic. The parser splits on whitespace and honours double quotes, so a topic can be quoted as one argument.

### Subcommands

| Form                    | Description                                                 |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| create <name> <topic>   | Starts a research project. See the flag table below.        |
| list [--all] [--json]   | Lists projects; --all includes archived, --json emits JSON. |
| show <name> [--json]    | Shows project state and findings; --json emits JSON.        |
| open <name>             | Opens the project's RESEARCH.md in the log panel.           |
| search <query> [--json] | Searches stored research content.                           |
| delete <name> [--yes]   | Deletes a project; --yes skips confirmation.                |
| archive <name>          | Moves a project to the archive.                             |
| resume <name>           | Resumes an interrupted or archived project.                 |

| Form                                                        | Description                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>continue &lt;name&gt; [--message &lt;text&gt;]</code> | Continues an existing project with an optional steering message.                              |
| <code>update &lt;name&gt;</code>                            | Refreshes an existing project's findings.                                                     |
| <code>cluster &lt;name&gt; [--force]</code>                 | Runs research clustering on the project; <code>--force</code> re-runs over existing clusters. |
| <code>export &lt;name&gt; [--output &lt;path&gt;]</code>    | Exports the project bundle to a path.                                                         |
| <code>import &lt;path&gt; [--name &lt;name&gt;]</code>      | Imports a project bundle, optionally renaming it.                                             |
| <code>config</code>                                         | Shows the resolved research configuration.                                                    |
| <code>help</code>                                           | Prints the subcommand table.                                                                  |

## Create flags

| Flag                                                 | Values / Default                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>--from-url, --from-url (repeatable)</code>     | Seed the run from one or more URLs.                                                                                                  |
| <code>--from-file, --from-file (repeatable)</code>   | Seed the run from local files.                                                                                                       |
| <code>--iterations N</code>                          | Iteration budget for the gather loop.                                                                                                |
| <code>--depth</code>                                 | <code>shallow   standard   deep</code> .                                                                                             |
| <code>--tier</code>                                  | <code>light   full   dissertation</code> .                                                                                           |
| <code>--mode</code>                                  | <code>tiered   supervisor   competitive</code> .<br><code>competitive</code> implies <code>--format comparison-table</code> .        |
| <code>--summarization-model</code>                   | <code>&lt;provider:model&gt;</code> override for summarisation.                                                                      |
| <code>--research-model</code>                        | <code>&lt;provider:model&gt;</code> override for the researcher stage.                                                               |
| <code>--compression-model</code>                     | <code>&lt;provider:model&gt;</code> override for compression.                                                                        |
| <code>--final-report-model</code>                    | <code>&lt;provider:model&gt;</code> override for the final report.                                                                   |
| <code>--max-concurrent-research-units N</code>       | Parallel research unit cap.                                                                                                          |
| <code>--format</code>                                | <code>report   executive-summary   comparison-table   source-bibliography   imrad</code> .                                           |
| <code>--sources-dir &lt;dir&gt;</code>               | Local sources directory to cross-reference.                                                                                          |
| <code>--template &lt;name&gt;</code>                 | Output template override.                                                                                                            |
| <code>--fetch-concurrently N</code>                  | Concurrent fetch cap (default 10).                                                                                                   |
| <code>--local-concurrently N</code>                  | Concurrent local-file reads (default 8).                                                                                             |
| <code>--fetch-timeout-secs N</code>                  | Per-fetch timeout (default 30).                                                                                                      |
| <code>--web-phase-timeout-secs / --web-time N</code> | Web phase budget.                                                                                                                    |
| <code>--local-phase-timeout-secs N</code>            | Local phase budget.                                                                                                                  |
| <code>--search-max-retries N</code>                  | Search retry count (default 2).                                                                                                      |
| <code>--search-retry-base-delay-ms N</code>          | Retry backoff base (default 200).                                                                                                    |
| <code>--max-web-results N</code>                     | Web result cap.                                                                                                                      |
| <code>--max-search-calls N</code>                    | Search-call cap.                                                                                                                     |
| <code>--max-local-sources N</code>                   | Local source cap.                                                                                                                    |
| <code>--max-synthesis-sources N</code>               | Sources admitted into synthesis.                                                                                                     |
| <code>--max-concepts N</code>                        | Output cap on the <code>## Concepts</code> list (default 5; 0 = unbounded). Per-run override of <code>research.max_concepts</code> . |

| Flag                                  | Values / Default                                                                                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>--max-findings N</code>         | Output cap on the <code>## Findings</code> list (default 20; 0 = unbounded). Per-run override of <code>research.max_findings</code> .                                                          |
| <code>--brief &lt;text&gt;</code>     | Provide the brief up front, skipping clarification.                                                                                                                                            |
| <code>--use-local</code>              | Include local file sources.                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <code>--use-specs</code>              | Include spec documents as sources.                                                                                                                                                             |
| <code>--use-low-relevance</code>      | Keep low-relevance hits.                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <code>--no-papers</code>              | Exclude scholarly-paper engines (OpenAlex) before any search request. Alias: <code>--no-scholarly</code> .                                                                                     |
| <code>--use-pdf</code>                | Enable PDF extraction.                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <code>--clarify / --no-clarify</code> | Force on or off the clarification stage. Off by default.                                                                                                                                       |
| <code>--evaluate</code>               | Enable evaluation scoring of findings.                                                                                                                                                         |
| <code>--url-cloak</code>              | Emit web source URLs as defanged plain text ( <code>hxxps://host[.]tld/...</code> in a code span) in the <code>Sources</code> bullets and <code>References</code> Index table. Off by default. |

## Examples

```
/research create rust-async "Compare tokio and async-std task scheduling models"
```

Names the project `rust-async`, uses everything after it as the topic.

```
/research create deep-dive "tree-sitter incremental parsing" --tier dissertation --depth deep
```

Runs a deep, dissertation-tier project.

```
/research create db-compare "sqlite vs duckdb analytics" --mode competitive
```

Competitive mode forces `--format comparison-table` output.

```
/research create local-audit "unsafe usage" --sources-dir ./crates --use-local --use-specs
```

Cross-references local crates and spec documents.

```
/research create fast "tokio broadcast channels" --tier light --fetch-concurrently 20 --web-phase
```

A light run with a raised fetch concurrency and web budget.

```
/research create brief "vector databases" --max-concepts 3 --max-findings 10
```

Caps the report to 3 concepts and 10 findings (most-relevant-first).

```
/research create exhaustive "multi-agent orchestration" --max-concepts 0 --max-findings 0
```

Disables both output caps (0 means unbounded).

```
/research create vendors "managed vector database vendors" --url-cloak
```

Defangs web URLs in the report so automated scanners do not treat them as clickable links.

```
/research create rerun "existing project" --summarization-model ollama:qwen2.5:1.5b
```

Routes the summarisation stage to a fast local model.

```
/research list --all
```

Lists every project including archived ones.

```
/research continue rust-async --message "Focus on the cancellation paths"
```

Continues a project with steering guidance.

## Output

- While running, the status bar shows `[wait] research: <name>...` and the pipeline streams progress lines into the message window.
- On completion the project's `RESEARCH.md` is written and a summary block lists the report path, source counts, and synthesis highlights.
- `list` renders a project table; `--json` variants emit machine-readable output for scripting.
- Failures print the failing stage with a corrective message; the project remains resumable via `/research resume`.

## Related

- `ragent research` CLI runs the same engine outside the TUI.
- `GET/POST/DELETE /research` HTTP endpoints mirror these operations.
- `/research cluster` relies on the research clustering engine.
- See `docs/research-phase2-plan.md` and the research system docs for internals.